

« My parents' encouragement and constant love are the reasons I could achieve it all »

LEANDER PAES

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Leander Paes reflects as the winter sun fades in Kolkata, the city where his childhood aspirations of tennis greatness took root. From the penthouse of an iconic building, he gazes over the vast green expanse known as the Maidan, lost in a flood of memories. The Maidan, home to major city clubs, holds a special place in Leander's heart, where he accompanied his accomplished athlete parents and found the inspiration to become a champion himself.

Leander shared with *Sportstar* the significance of being the first male player from Asia to be inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame

(player category). He dedicated this prestigious award to his greatest motivators — his parents — and the millions of Indians who supported him.

What does this Hall of Fame mean to Indian tennis?

I always like to lead by example, and this, I hope, inspires all the youth in our country and shows them that from playing gully cricket or playing gully football barefoot, I could come so far. So, if they have enough passion and can work hard, they,

too, can get into the Hall of Fame. It's about telling them that if you believe in yourself and put in the hard work, it is possible to fulfil your dreams.

Being the first Asian male to be nominated in the player's category, it's a tribute that I would like to give to my parents. Their encouragement and constant love are the reasons I could achieve it all. They allowed an 11-year-old boy to leave home and pursue his dreams. That's not common in Indian culture, and that too in a sport like tennis, where India has never had a Grand Slam winner before me. The sport did not have an Olympic champion before me, so it was not easy for them to allow me to chase my dreams. Allowing your child to pursue disciplines like cricket



Tennis is one of the toughest sports on the planet. As a sport, it is demanding, and it's also hard physically, mentally, and financially.